CONTACT & COMMUNICATION

Setup guide

WhatsApp, live chat, and your contact inbox

This guide explains how the portfolio messaging features work, how to connect their services, and how to verify that an enquiry reaches the private inbox.

What is included

- **WhatsApp:** a floating button opens a chat with a prefilled greeting; no API key is needed.
- **Live chat:** Tawk.to loads independently once its public widget IDs are configured.
- **Contact form:** saves validated messages in Supabase; the administrator can view, mark read/unread, and delete them.
- **Email notification (optional):** Resend can send an alert after successful message storage.

Keep .env.local private. Never commit it, share its contents, or put a service-role key into browser code or a NEXT_PUBLIC_ variable.

You need a Supabase project for saved enquiries and administrator login. Tawk.to and Resend accounts are optional. Start local development with `npm run dev` and open `http://localhost:3000`. Restart the dev server after changing environment variables.

1. WhatsApp and live chat

WhatsApp button

WhatsApp: +256 782 611 801 (Uganda)
Direct link: https://wa.me/256782611801
Prefilled message: Hello, I visited your website and would like to get in touch.

The button is already implemented and needs no environment configuration. To change the number or greeting, edit `components/WhatsAppButton.tsx`.

Tawk.to live chat (optional)

- Create a free account at tawk.to, add the website as a property, and open the widget settings.
- Copy the property ID and widget ID from the Tawk.to embed URL.
- Add these values to .env.local locally and to the hosting provider environment in production:

```
NEXT_PUBLIC_TAWK_PROPERTY_ID=your_property_id
NEXT_PUBLIC_TAWK_WIDGET_ID=default
```

Use the widget ID from your embed snippet if it differs from default. These are public widget identifiers, not account secrets. The site hides the widget if the property ID is blank. Restart or redeploy after setting them.

Verify the Tawk.to bubble appears in a fresh browser tab and check the Tawk.to dashboard for a visitor. The chat bubble and WhatsApp button are separate.

2. Supabase contact form

Create or open your Supabase project. Add the following values to your private .env.local file, or your production hosting settings:

Variable	Purpose	Secret?
NEXT_PUBLIC_SUPABASE_URL	Supabase project URL	No
NEXT_PUBLIC_SUPABASE_ PUBLISHABLE_KEY	Public key for sign-in and restricted form inserts	No
SUPABASE_SERVICE_ROLE_KEY	Server-side admin inbox access	**YES**
SUPABASE_ADMIN_EMAIL	Email allowed to manage messages	Private setting

Never add NEXT_PUBLIC_ to the service-role key. It bypasses database access controls and must stay server-side.

3. Database and administrator

Run both SQL files from the repository in Supabase Dashboard > SQL Editor, in this order:

- `supabase/migrations/20261106000000_create_contact_messages.sql` creates the table and enables row-level security.
- `supabase/migrations/20261106010000_allow_public_contact_submissions.sql` grants the public form permission to insert message fields only.

Public roles cannot read, update, or delete enquiries. Admin operations use the service-role key on the server after checking the signed-in user email.

Create the administrator account

- In Supabase Authentication, disable public sign-ups and create or invite the administrator whose email matches SUPABASE_ADMIN_EMAIL.
- Use a strong password and complete any required email confirmation.
- Set the environment variables locally or in the hosting provider; restart the local server or redeploy the site.

Sign in at `/admin/login`; the inbox is at `/admin/messages`. It displays sender, email, subject, message, submission date, and read status.

Optional Resend email alerts

Create a Resend account, verify a sender domain, and create an API key. Configure all three settings to enable notifications:

```
RESEND_API_KEY=your_resend_api_key
CONTACT_NOTIFICATION_TO=you@example.com
CONTACT_NOTIFICATION_FROM=Portfolio <contact@your-verified-domain.com>
```

Email alerts are optional. The message is saved first; a notification failure is logged and does not undo the saved enquiry. Keep the Resend key private.

Local vs. production configuration

- Local: copy .env.example to .env.local, fill in settings privately, and restart `npm run dev`.
- Production: configure variables in the hosting provider dashboard, not in client code or the repository. Redeploy after changes.
- .env.local is ignored by Git. Never commit it.

4. Verify and troubleshoot

End-to-end checklist

- Submit a valid test enquiry and confirm a success message.
- Sign in at /admin/login and confirm the test entry appears at /admin/messages.
- Toggle read/unread, then test deletion with a disposable message.
- If Resend is enabled, verify receipt and check its dashboard if missing.
- Test the WhatsApp link on desktop and mobile; confirm number and greeting.
- If Tawk.to is enabled, confirm its widget appears separately.
- Run npm run lint and npm run build before deploying.

Common errors

Error	What to check
Contact form is temporarily unavailable	Supabase URL or public key is missing or misspelled. Check local or hosting environment settings; restart/redeploy.
Your message could not be saved	Check Next.js server logs. Confirm migrations ran on the same Supabase project and public insert permission/policy exists.
PGRST205 / table not found	The contact_messages table is missing from this project or its API schema cache. Run the migrations in order.
Admin login or inbox unavailable	Check publishable key, server-only service key, configured admin email, and matching Supabase Auth account.
Tawk.to is not visible	Check property/widget IDs, restart/redeploy, and inspect browser network or ad-blocking settings.

For form failures, inspect the browser Network panel for POST /api/contact and check the Next.js server logs. Never share logs or screenshots containing credentials, tokens, or private messages.

Basic validation, same-origin checks, and a honeypot reduce common spam but are not full rate-limiting or CAPTCHA. Keep admin access limited. Rotate any credential that is exposed.